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NOTES ET DOCUMENTS

A TWELFTH CENTURY ARAB ACCOUNT OF INDIAN RELIGIONS AND SECTS

BY

M.S. KHAN, CALCUTTA

A comparative study of religions has been «rightly acclaimed as one of the great contributions of Muslim civilization to mankind's intellectual progress»[1]. And there were good reasons for it. Without doubt, the two most important reasons were the deep attachment of the Muslims to their own religion and their direct contact with the major religions of the world at the beginning of their history. Their interest in philosophy, which also included religion, as in modern times, may be considered as another reason. Among them, religious discussions and disputes both oral and written were held at Baghdad reports of some of which are available now[2].

Arab Writers on the Indian Religions

It is recorded that Mālik bin Dīnār, a companion of the Prophet, first arrived in South India leading to the earlest direct contact between Islam and Hinduism. The Muslims must have come in contact with the Buddhists at Samarqand (conquered in 92/711) and other parts of Central Asia. Close relations between Hindus and Muslims developed after the conquest of Sind and the Punjab in 712 A.D. As a result, a Hindu scientist most probably from Sindh visited the Court of the 'Abbasid Caliph Abū J'afar al-Manṣūr (754-775 A.D.) at Baghdad in 154/771)[3]. The cultured Barmakid family, which provided several viziers for the Abbasids were of Indian origin and their forefathers were Buddhists. One of them Yaḥyā bin Khālid (786-803 A.D.) sent an envoy to India in order to collect information about Indian religions.

The report submitted by the said envoy is not altogether lost. Its summary is preserved in the *Kitāb al-Fihrist* of Ibn an-Nadīm which contains a chapter on the Indian religions under the caption *Madhāhib al-Hind* (Religions of India) covering 4 pages of Book IX, Chapter 2 i.e. pp. 345-349[4]. Several Arab writers also provided information on the

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This is a revised and augmented version of my Review Article concerning the book *Shahrastānī on Indian Religions* by Bruce B. Lawrence (The Hague, 1976) pp. 297 published in *Islam and Modern Age*, New Delhi for May, 1980, pp. 204-229.

I acknowledge that Drs. H.K. De Chaudhury, (Mrs.) Prabhati Mukherji, Ramkrishna Bhattacharya and Shri Uma Pada Sen all of Calcutta have read this paper and offered criticism an suggestions for which I offer them my sincere thanks.

[1] Franz Rosenthal in the preface of the book entitled *Shahrastani on the Indian Religions* by Bruce B. Lawrence (Mouton: The Hague-Paris, 1976) pp. 297 at p. 5.

[2] See pp. 75 and 76 of Bruce B. Lawrence's Book.

[3] See M.S. Khan, «Aryabhata I and al-Bīrūnī» in the *Indian Journal of History of Science*, Vol. XII, No. 2, pp. 237-244.

[4] G. Flügel's edition (Leipzig, 1872) 2 Vols. As it was published more than a century ago, it needs revision and correction.

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subject, such as the Arab geographers from Ibn Khurradādbih to Sharīf al-Idrīsī. Arab merchants, travellers and historians, who visited India, also recorded information about Indian religious practices. A substantial chapter on Indian religions is found in the *Kitāb al-Bad' wat-Ta'rikh* of Muṭahhar bin Ṭāhir al-Maqdīsī[5] (d. 335/946) and others. Al-Bīrūnī (d. 1048 A.D.) claims to have preserved information contained in the lost work entitled *Kitāb ad-Diyānāt* of Abu 'l-'Abbas Īrānshahrī. Statements about Indian religions are contained in the *Kitāb al-Mu'tazila* of Murtaḍa Zaidī and the *Kitāb al-Farq bayn al-Firaq* of Abdu'l-Qāhir al-Baghdādī. What al-Bīrūnī has written on Indian religions and philosophy in his book is not only authentic but also critical based mainly on original Sanskrit texts and personal observations[6]. These are some of the brilliant pages written on the subject in Arabic. In 460/1068, eighteen years before the birth of al-Shahrastānī in 479/1086, Abu'l-Qasim Qāḍī Ṣā'id al-Andalusī wrote the *Ṭabaqāt al-Umam* at Toledo, of which the first chapter deals with ancient sciences and culture which also briefly discusses the religions of India[7]. But a substantial chapter on this subject is found in the *Kitāb al-Milal wan-Niḥal* of Abu'l-Fatḥ Muhammad bin Abdu'l Karīm-al Shahrastānī, (d. 549/1153) entitled *Ārā'ahl al-Hind*[8], of which a thorough study is presented in this paper. Among others Gardīzī and al-Marwazī also wrote on Indian religions in Persian.

Summary of the Content

The chapter opens with a statement that the people of India are divided into three communities, viz.: The Brahmins, The Naturalists and the Dualists. It is stated that the majority of the Indians are Sabeans, and all of them can be divided into five groups.

The Brahmins — the followers of spiritual beings, the proponents of heavenly bodies, the idol-worshippers and the philosophers.

The Brahmins are named after a Man called Brahma. They deny prophecy altogether and attempt to prove the irrationality of prophecy. Four arguments are recorded against prophecy and al-Shahrastānī puts forward his own arguments in its favour. The author mentions four sub-sects of the Brahmans: those who belong to the followers of the Buddha; the proponents of meditation and the adherents to metempsychosis. The teachings of the Buddha are then explained and the proponents of meditation and imagination are considered to be experts in astrology and astronomy adding: «Sometimes meditation unlocks supernatural circumstances; sometimes it is able to hold back rains and sometimes it directs the imagination on a living man and kills him instantly»[9]. One of the sub-sects mentioned is *BAKRANTINIYA*. It is stated that the proponents of metempsychosis differ as to the length of the largest revolution. Most of them maintain that

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[5] Ed. by Cl. Huart, Arabic text vol. IV, (Paris, 1907); Tehran repr. of 1962 pp. 9-19.

[6] See the Arabic ed. of his *Fī Taḥqiq mā li'l-Hind* (Hyderabad, 1377/1958) pp. 548 at pp. 20-71.

[7] See M.S. Khan, «An Eleventh Century Hispano-Arabic Source for Ancient Indian Science and Culture» in the Prof. H. K. Sharwani Felicitation Volume (Hyderabad, 1975), pp. 357-389.

[8] Cureton text pp. 444-458. Text ed. by Md. Syed Kilani, 2nd. ed. (Beirut, 1395/1975) Vol. II. pp. 250-263; on the margin of Ibn Ḥazm's *al-Fiṣal*. 5 Vols. (Beirut: Khayyat, n.d.) Vol. III, pp. 263-264.

[9] Bruce B. Lawrence has presented a thorough study of this chapter in his book mentioned in note I above. See p. 44.

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it is 30,000 years; others say it is 360,000 years [10]. According to their followers, the Spiritual Beings are the divine messengers who came to this world in human form without a written testimony. The different sects in which their followers are divided are stated to be the Basawiya or perhaps Vasudeviya; Bahuwadiya or Mahādeviya, Kabaliya or Kapalika and Bahaduniya. Among the worshippers of the planets, the Dinakitya or Sun-worshippers and Jandarikaniya or Moon-worshippers are mentioned. In so far as the idol worshippers of India are concerned, al-Shahrastānī mentions not less than five sects [11]: the Mahakaliya or Mahakala-worshippers, the Barkashikiya or Vṛksa-bhaktas or tree-worshippers; the Dankiniya perhaps from Dakīnī or witch; the Jalshakiya or Jalosvakiya or water-worshippers and Akniwatriya or Agnihotriya or fire-worshippers, which is the name of Brahman takes when he serves three fires.

The last section of this chapter deals with Indian philosophers who are supposed to be the followers of Pythagoras's student Qalanus who came to India ans settled in it. They are divided into two groups: — One of which considered eating, drinking, procreation and other pleasures of life as permissible, while the other considered procreation as sin [12]. Their doctrine about the Almighty Creator is that, he is pure Light [13], but He takes on some bodily shapes for conealment so that He is seen only by those fit and suitable to see Him. Indeed, the Creator is like one who puts on the hide of an animal in this world; then when he takes it off, someone whose glance falls on Him can look at Him, but if He does not put it on, no one is able to see Him». The chapter ends with the story of Alexander in India in which the philosophers of India are shown to be superior to those accompanying Alexander.

Sources of this Chapter.

The problem of the sources of a medieval text is difficult to solve if its author does not give specific indications. There are two difficulties—first, the Arab and Persian authors of medieval times seldom mention their sources. Secondly, this dependence is not total and the text from which information is borrowed is not copied verbatim. Moreover, information obtained from different sources is mixed together. Further, the fact that two authors borrow from the same source without acknowledgement complicates the problem.

Al-Shahrastānī has stated that his chapter on Indian religions is based on «*Fī Kutubihim al-Mashhūra*» or «the best known of their books» [14] but he has not specified their titles. In so far as the original sources of the Indian religions are concerned they were written mostly in Sanskrit or Pali and it is most unlikely that al-Shahrastānī knew either of these languages. He does not mention even one title in Arabic or Persian which he used for writing this chapter while in the case of Magianism he mentions Jayhānī as his source. However, Muṭahhar bin Ṭāhir al-Maqdīsī mentions *Kitāb al-Masālik Wa'l-Mamālik* (without mentioning the author) and Gardīzī and al-Marwazī specify Jayhānī [15] to be their sources for the religions of India.

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[10] Bruce B. Lawrence, op. cit., p. 47.
[11] *Ibid.*, pp. 52-55.
[12] *Ibid.*, p. 57.
[13] Cf. *Bhagavat-Gita* also portrays God as pure light.
[14] Beirut ed. of the text. Vol. II, p. 250.
[15] Gardīzī mentions Abū 'Abdullāh Jayhānī twice as his source for the chapter on India-*Andar Ma'ārif Hindwān*; see Zayn al-Akhbār ed. by 'Abdu'l-Ḥayy Ḥabībī (Tehran, 1347 A. H. Shamsi) pp. 286, 299.

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In the case of this chapter there is another difficulty in identifying its sources. Its text was written quite late when the major works in Arabic and Persian dealing with Indian religions had already been written. Nevertheless, a comparison of al-Shahrastānī's text with those of al-Maqdīsī and Ibn an-Nadīm [16] will establish, beyond any reasonable doubt, that he borrowed information from them either directly or through intermediaries. But he did not copy from them verbatim. He selected whatever information on the Indian religions interested him and paraphrased their texts in his own language, supplementing or interpolating additional information from other sources. This is what other Arab writers of the medieval period generally did. For this reason it is not possible to trace the original source of every bit of information contained in this chapter. It is, however, certain that the writings of al-Bīrūnī on Indian religions and philosophy were not used by him. It has to be emphasized that al-Shahrastānī never visited India, like al-Masʿūdī, al-Bīrūnī and others, so that he was not in a position to record any information on the basis of personal knowledge. It is known whether he came in contact with any traveller, geographer, merchant or historian who had visited any part of India and passed on information to him (p. 29). Therefore, it can safely be stated that the sources of this chapter are mainly literary.

Its opening passage resembles a passage in the *Ṭabaqāt* of Qāḍī Ṣāʿid al-Andalusi [17]. Both authors divide the masses of India into Brahima and Sabia or Brahmans and Sabeans. They also note the influence of Saturn on the destiny of the Indians and state that the Brahmins reject prophethood. Although it may not be suggested that al-Shahrastānī knew the text of the *Ṭabaqāt* yet the possibility that both of them used a common source cannot completely be ruled out. It is evident that Gardīzī was one of the sources of the author and the former depended on Abū ʿAbdullāh Jayḥānī [18] and mentioned him twice as his source in his chapter on India. Thus it may be said that he used Jayhani's material indirectly.

Noteworthy is the fact that the term Samaniya (*Sramaṇa* in Sanskrit) used for the Buddhists by most of the Arab authors is not used by al-Shahrastānī. Al-Bīrūnī, (Īvānshahrī); Marwazī, Gardīzī, Maqdīsī, Ibn an-Nadīm, Jayḥānī, al-Masʿūdī, Qāḍī Ṣāʿid al-Andalusī, Ḥamza al-Iṣfahānī and other wrote on Buddha and Buddhism prior to al-Shahrastānī, Ḥamza records that Samaniya or Buddhists live mainly in the east, in India, China and Khurasan [19], but he does not discuss the Teaching of Buddhism as in this chapter. It cannot be stated for certain whether the author used the *Kitāb al-Budd* and *Kitāb al-Bilawhar wa Būdhāsf* or not.

A minor problem which will remain unsolved for the present is the source of the sect called BARKASHIKIYA which has not been noticed by any other author who flourished before al-Shaharastānī.

Hindu Sects.

The Hindu sects noticed here are thirteen in number. Of the eight sects mentioned by Ibn an-Nadīm, six have been noticed by al-Sharastānī. But the largest number of them

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[16] Ibn an-Nadīm's chapter on India has been studied by A. B. M. Habibullah as «An Early Arab Report on Indian Religious Sects» in *History and Society* ed. by Debiprasad Chattopsdhyaya (Calcutta, 1976) pp. 642 at 433.

[17] Louis Chiekho ed. (Beyrouth, 1912) pp. 124 at pp. 11-15.

[18] See note 15 above.

[19] See *Taʾrīkh Sinī Mulūk al-Arḍ waʾl-Anbiyāʾ* (Beyrouth: Dar Maktabat al-Hayat, 1961, p. 11.

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recorded by Gardīzī is «twenty-three», on the basis of the report left by Jayḥānī [20]. Some are noticed in this chapter also some are not. Several Indian sects are mentioned by al-Maqdīsī and Marwazī. Al-Sharastānī either drew his information from al-Kindi's book directly or from Ibn an-Nadīm's report based on it. A comparison will establish that the statements of this chapter on Hindu sects are related more to the account of Gardīzī than to that of any other author. But this was the one and only tradition which the author knew and followed. The other tradition of the Indian religions represented by Zurqān, Ĭrānshahrī and, last but not the least, the great historian and scientist al-Bīrūnī was not known to him [21].

Modern scholars have discussed the Sabeans and the Arabic sources of their doctrines but it is time now that the Arabic tradition of the Sabeans which is not necessarily identical with their original teachings be reconstructed. The questions about the Sabeans this chapter raises are not easy to answer and require further research. An important dissertation about the Sabeans was written and published in Sweden by Jan Hjarpe: *Analyse critique des traditions arabes sur les Sabeans Harraniens* (Uppsala, 1972). The «aṣ-Ṣābi'ūn» in the *Chār 'Ilmī Maqālāt* by Sa'īd Aḥmed Akbarābādī (Aligarh, 1967) pp. 102 at 1-40; Victor Kek, *Role des Sabeans de Harran dans la Civilisation Islamique* (Beirut, 1971) pp. 81 in Urdu and Persian respectively may be mentioned here. Useful information about the Sabeans is also recorded by Qāḍī Ṣā'id al-Andalusī in his *Ṭabaqāt*.

All the same, the conclusion drawn on the basis of written evidences bearing on the sources of this chapter may not be considered final and there will always remain some scope for revision and correction.

Proper and Place Names.

The Indian proper names are of non-Arabic origin and it was difficult for the scribe to write them correctly; but they are not many. The mount Jur'an on which a temple of the Bahadunia sect is situated is difficult to identify. In the new edition of Gardīzī's *Zayn al-Akhbār*, this name appears as Jun Ghar (pp. 293-94) which led Minorsky to identify it with Junagarh. G. Flügel, the editor of the *Fihrist* of Ibn-an-Nadīm, could not identify it (II, 183). He records another reading as *Hur 'An*. The editor of the new edition of the Zayn al-Akhbar writes in a note (p. 293, note 15) that there is still a mountain called Chan Ghar in the valley of Ghūr in Afganistan [22]. This writer believes that this mountain cannot be located nor its correct name ascertained as long as the sect BAHADUNIYA is not identified correctly.

It can be stated with certainty that the huge idol of Mahākāla was located at Ujjain and not at Akhtar as stated by a modern scholar. In the new edition of Gardīzī it is mentioned incorrectly as Ajar (p. 249) but Gardīzī himself states categorically that the town of Ujjain was the stronghold of the Mahākāla sect [23], which leaves no doubt whatsoever. Similarly, there cannot be any doubt that the river mentioned on p. 43 is *Kank* (Ganges or Sanskrit, Ganga) and not *Kil*. It has been mentioned correctly as Kank or Ganges under Basawiya (p. 48) in this very chapter which proves that the correct name

[20] V. Minorsky «Gardīzī on India» in the *Iranica*. Twenty Articles. (1964) pp. 200-215; Text ed. cited pp. 286-299.

[21] Text ed. of *Kitāb al-Hind* cited pp. 4-5.

[22] 'Abdu'l-Ḥayy Ḥabībī, p. 293 note 15 states that the word *ghar* meaning a mountain is still in use in Pashtu.

[23] *Op. cit.*, p. 288 has: *wa Shahr Ujjain Ke Mahākaliyan bāshand.*

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of this river was known to al-Sharastānī. However, its name may not be uniform in the Arabic sources. For example, al-Mas'ūdī mentions it as Janjis (*Murūj*, 1,112) and the Arab geographerr give different forms. It is almost certain that (جبن) became (جنر or خنر) and (كنك) became (كيل) due to incorrect transcription. In both cases the incorrect forms are quite close and similar to the correct ones. Both these names were foreign to the scribe and in Arabic MSS such instances of incorrect transcription of foreign words are common.

Two proper names appearing in this chapter are baffling, for instance Qalamus, a student of Pythagoras who visited India and taught his philosophy to the Indian sage-King Brahmanan. This reviewer has consulted the accounts of «Fithaghoras» in the available Arabic histories of the philosophers and scientists such as those by Abū Sulaymān al-Sijistānī, Ibn Juljul, Mubashshar bin Fātik, Qādī Ṣā'id al-Andalusī, al-Sharazūrī, al-Qifṭī, Ibn Abī Uṣaybi'a and others but did not find any name similar to Qalanus who was a student of Pythagoras [24]. But this story is found in the *al-Āthār al-Bāqiyah* of al-Bīrūnī on the authority of Ammonius the Greek, but the forms of the two names differ [25]. They appear to be Qalabus and Barkhmash. But the original source of this story is Ammonius, no doubt. Obviously, these are cases of incorrect and corrupt transcription of the names of these two legendary figures. It is said that Alexander took one Indian philosopher with him to Macedonia [26]. In the *Indica* of Megasthenes two Brahman philosophers Kalanos and Dandamis are mentioned. It is stated that Kalanos loved money more than asceticism. He took the service of Alexander and was disdained by his own people [27].

Identification of Hindu Sects.

A modern scholar has tried to identify the correct names of Hindu sects and their idols in Sanskrit and one can agree with most of them. The problem of finding out the correct Sanskrit equivalent of these names in Arabic forms as they are found in this text is complicated for two reasons. First, the difficulty of Arabic translitteration of these foreign names; second, their pronunciation has also created difficulties and they have become so corrupt in their present Arabic forms that it is impossible to find out their Sanskrit equivalent in each case; examples of such words are Bakrantiniya and Bahaduniya, for which all kinds of guesses may be made. The Vāsudevīya and Mahādeviya have become Basawya and Bahuwadiya in Arabic. It may be suggested that the Barkashikiya is the corrupt form of *Vṛkṣabhaktas* who are tree worshippers. Further, Dankiniya may be Dākinīya from Sanskrit *Dakīnī* which may mean a witch whose followers have been correctly identified as *Bhagavatī-bhaktas*.

Al-Bīrūnī's *Indica* does not record a list of the Indian sects as in this chapter but it described some of the idols which these sects worshipped. For these descriptions al-Biruni

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[24] F. Rosenthal, «Fithaguras» in the *Enc. of Islam*, new ed. Vol. II, (1965), 929-930.

[25] See Johann Fück, Sechs Erganzungen zu Sachaus Ausgabe von al-Bīrūnīs Chronologie Orientalischer Volker in the *Documenta Islamica Inedita* (Berlin, 1952), pp. 69-98 at 76.

[26] He was the same Kalanos whose original name was Shinos who was one of the Indian philosophers who accompanied Alexander. R.C. Majumdar has noticed him on the authority of Plutarch. Another name mentioned is Bachmanes. See R.C. Majumdar's *The Classical Accounts of India* (Calcutta, 1960), pp. 504 at 187, 201-202, 378-280.

[27] Magasthenes and Arrian *McCrindle's Ancient India as Described by* ... ed. by Ramchandra Jain (New Delhi, 1972) pp. 263; see pp. 106, 115, 116, 122, 123, 127.

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mentions the *Bṛhat Saṃhitā* of Varāhamihira, ca. A.D. 505, (pp. 89ff.). The accounts of this chapter can be compared with those of al-Bīrūnī, for example, the idols of the Sun and Mahadeva (p. 89). It is found that the two accounts have nothing in common. According to the statement of al-Bīrūnī if a Brahmin serves three fires he is called *Agnihotrin* (p. 77), but the author gives this title to all the worhippers of fire in India.

Merits and Demerits.

It now remains to discuss the merits and demerits of this chapter as a source on Indian religions. Without doubt, al-Shahrastānī has faithfully recorded whatever information he found in his sources, following a certain principle of selection which does not articulate, but his objective reporting is praiseworthy. Śiva is mentioned only once as the spiritual angel of the Kāpālika sect, but not Visnu or Indra, in matters of religion, was Śaivite and not Vaiṣṇavite. For this reason, perhaps the followers of the sects are shown to undergo severe physical torture so that the soul can achieve salvation only by release from the body. It is evident that the sources recorded no information about the religion of the Vedic period and this text does not mention the four Vedas [28]. This chapter's contents agree well with those of the Brahmanical texts when the Brahmans had become all powerful after the Vedic period. The belief in metempsychosis and transmigration of the soul is not found in the Vedas, but is a strong point in this chapter. It is found for the first time in the *Śatapatha Brahmana*. These are common beliefs in both Hinduism and Buddhism. Without doubt, al-Shahrastānī's discourse on Indian religions is related to the eighth century (A.D.). Sacrifice by slaughtering animals had become a popular religous practice at this time among the Hindus.

In the beginning of this chapter the Brahmans are stated to be naturalist and dualist. The former may be a vague reference to Samkhya school of philosophy or SVABHAVABADA which is a proto-Lokayata doctrine and the latter to the sect called Dvaitavadins which originated after Sankara [29]. They believed that nature is the cause of birth and decay of all beings. There is no necessity of imagining a God or a creator. Al-Shahrastānī's account of spiritual beings is partially correct and it is correctly stated that they differed from the prophets. He refers to the followers of Vasudeva and their practices as recorded by him are correct in many respects.

The statement of the Arab writers that the Brahmans reject prophethood is not difficult to understand, as their doctrine of divine incarnation is that God descends on the earth for the guidance of man in the form of a man or *avatara* which is *nuzūl*. According to the Indian belief they need not bring any book because they are divine beings themselves in the garb of men. This is very different from the Jewish, Christian and Muslim concept of a prophet, who is an ordinary human being chosen by God so that he can carry His message to the people [30]. Necessarily, he would bring a book as proof containing the

[28] Al-Biruni devotes one full chapter of his book on the Vedas, the Puranas etc. See the text ed. cited pp. 96-104.

[29] On the Indian materialism see al-Bīrūnī who writes: the book Laukayata composed by Brihaspati treating of the subject that in al investigations we must exclusively rely upon the appreciation of the senses. Text cited p. 102; Sachau's tr. 1, p. 132. See also Debiprasad Chattopadhyaya, *Lokayata: A Study in Ancient Indian Materialism* (New Delhi, 1959) pp. 696.

[30] See «Muslim Scholars on Properthood in Islam» in the *Review of Religions*. Vol. LXVII/9 (1972) pp. 270-274. Alfred Guillaume. Prophecy and Devination among the Hebrews and other Semites (London 1938).

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Commandments of God as in the case of Moses, Jesus, Muḥammad and others. They are prophets (*rasūl*)—sent by God but not themselves God. The Muslim writers believe that the most important sign of a prophet is that he brings a book from God. So al-Shahrastānī also meticulously notes down that the Indian divine messengers in human form did not bring any book from God (pp. 251-52).

The sub-section on Buddhism contains information which are not found in any other Medieval Arabic source, for example, the Buddhist belief in reward and punishment and in the eternity of the world. Moreover, the five fundamental virtues, a list of ten virtues to be cultivated and a list of ten vices to be avoided contained in it are not found elsewhere. The five fundamental virtues may be equated with Four Noble Truths of the early Buddhist teaching. Roughly speaking, the eight fold path of the Budha (*aṣṭangika mārga*) for attaining these truths, namely, right view, right thought, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness and right concentration are also recorded in a different and expanded form in this chapter in the two lists of virtues and vices. It has been correctly stated that the virtues are to be cultivated and vices avoided to attain the path of truth[31]. (*Sabīl al-Ḥaq*). Shakamin or Śākyamuni as one of the names of the Buddha is correct. It is correctly stated that *Budisaiva* or Bodhisativas are those saints who are on the right path of perfection. But the author does not mention his source or sources and they cannot be identified at present (see above). Moreover, in the first sentence the characterisation of the Buddha as one who is not born etc., no doubt applies to him when he had already attained the *Nirvāna*. The author does not seem to know that Buddhism was divided into two main schools—the MAHAYANA and the HINAYANA. It was also not known to him that shaving the hair of the head and face started with the Buddhists.

The value of this chapter is considerably limited by the sources available to al-Shahrastānī which were only of a secondary nature. When al-Bīrūnī writes on Indian religion, he goes back to the original Sanskrit sources and quotes extensively from the Hindu scriptures. The *Mahabhārata*, the *Bhāgawat-gītā*, the *Sankhya* of Kapila and the *Book of Patañjali* were available to him and he uses them when he discourses on God, soul, matter, universe and other metaphysical subjects according to the Hindus in a highly critical and scientific manner[32]. He had a fairly good working knowledge of Sanskrit, which al-Shahrastānī did not possess. For this reason, the latter copies here whatever erroneous information he finds in his sources and does not subject them to any critical scrutiny, for example, like others he makes an erroneous statement that Brahma was a man's name. It was actually the name of a Deity which also stands for the Absolute[33]. He also notices Buddhism as a branch of Hinduism erroneously as Islam was considered in Europe to be a Christian heresy in the Middle ages. Hindu religious books translated by al-Biruni into Arabic, for example, the Book of Patañjali, were not available to him[34].

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[31] Minian Smart, «Buddhism» in the *Enc. of Philosophy*, Vol. I (New York, 1976), 416-430.

[32] See M.S. Khan, «Al-Bīrūnī and Indian Metaphysics» in the *Islamic Culture* (Hyderabad, July 1981) pp. 161-168.

[33] Al-Mas'ūdī states that «Brahman» was the name of a great king of India. *Murūj adh-Dhahab*, ed. by Charles Pellat (Beyrouth, 1966), Vol. I, pp. 84, 88.

[34] The Arabic tr. was published by H. Ritter, «Al-Bīrūnī's Übersetzung des Yoga-Shutra des Patañjali», in the *Oriens*, IX (1956). See also S. Pines and T. Gelblum, «Al-Biruni's Arabic Version of Patañjali's Yogasutra», in *Oriens*, XX (1967).

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Without doubt, this chapter contains facts and fiction mixed together. It is correct to state that except al-Bīrūnī the Arab authors possessed little or no knowledge of the original sources for Indian religions.

Like most of the medieval Arab writers, the authors's sense of chronology is very defective indeed. He states that five thousand years have passed from time of the appearance of the Buddha to the migration of the Prophet, in 622 A.D. But now the generally accepted view is that Buddha lived during the period 653 to 483 B.C. which means that he appeared only 1182 years before the migration (*hijra*). One can see how wide off the mark is the author's calculation[35].

Similarly, under the sub-chapter "The Proponents of Metempsychosis or Transmigration", he writes about the celestial bodies moving in a circle, which is correct, but it is stated that they put the length of the largest revolution between 360,000 and 30,000 years. The source of this information is not indicated but according to the Siddhanta method all the planets are assembled at the head of Aries once in 4320,000,000 solar years. At this conjunction all created things on the earth are destroyed till the planets are dispersed amongst the signs of the Zodiac when life begins afresh and the lower world returns to its former state. Each of the planets accomplishes certain revolutions during this period[36]. There are many incorrect statements made by the author about the astronomy and astrology of the Indians and the Greeks under the sub-chapter. The Proponents of Meditation and Imagination». Even from the Vedic period the largest planet according to Indian astronomy was not Saturn, as stated by the author, but it was Jupiter—the Brhatakpati. In astrology also Jupiter, not Saturn, is the most benevolent planet for India. The Greeks did not make astrological predictions from the nature of the stars, and the Indians do not predict on the basis of their properties. The astrological predictions of both Grece and India are almost identical and for both of them planets also are important.

It is hardly possible to agree with a modern scholar who identifies "The Proponents of Meditation and Imagination" as as Rsis only[37]. It would be more accurate to identify them as the asceties called Yogis or Munis as their description in this chapter agrees rather with the latter than with the former as there is an emphasis on meditation. Perhaps the statement of the Veda that a man with the knowledge of the celestial sphere is Rsis and their description found in Maqdīsī, Candīzī and Marvazī have influenced him to arrive at this conclusion.

The first stage in Indian meditation is to shut up the mind so that the thought process is stopped. The Indian Yogis attach no importance to thought. The object of Yoga is to make the mind inactive[38] so that the sublimation of the Ego is realised. Thus one can abstain from realising the properties carried through the senses. The behaviour of the soul is not affected by human imagination. In Yoga the eyes are closed so that the sense organs cannot perceive anything, but this does not stop the mind from thinking, and this has to be stopped by certain breathing exercise and other methods. The statement that meditation sometimes directs the imagination on a living man and kills him instantly

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[35] Al-Mas'udi states that Buddha appeared 12000 times 33,000 years ago which seems to be absurd. See his *Kitāb at-Tanbih wa'l-Ishrāf*, ed. by De Goeje (Beirut, Khayyat reprint, 1965) p. 201.

[36] See M.S. Khan's Paper mentioned in note 7 above; pp. 360; 377-78.

[37] Meditation is *dhiyāna* and imagination is *kalpana*.

[38] See *Patañjali Jodgarshan* tr. by Harihārananda Aranya (Calcutta University Publ. 1938).

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(p. 44) gives the impression that the author was mixing meditation with black magic. Forty educated and morally irreprochable men are never called together to consider a situation as stated in this chapter but the author might be referring to the *Panchayat* in the village society of India.

Evidently, several statements under, "The Proponents of Metempsychosis and Transference" are incorrect. The celestial orbits caused by the fixed starts were not taken into consideration by Indian astrologers and astronomers. The Hindu astronomers did not believe that each celestial orbit was composed of water, fire and wind as stated by al-Shahrastānī but such compositions were introduced in the course of astrological calculations in respect of the twelve signs of the Zodiac.

At least at two places in this chapter the author's approach is subjective and somewhat critical. He copies the arguments put forward by the Brahmins in rejecting prophethood, but he defends his own belief in it, quoting several verses from the Quran [39]. Moreover, he criticizes the worshippers of idols stating that they consider them divine beings and merely not intermediaries between men and God [40]. But he did not know that the Hindus consider it as symbolic worship (*PRATIKOPASANA*) which al-Bīrūnī clearly understood. The latter thought that only common and aliterate Hindus worship idols while the highly educated among them abstain from doing so. He goes to the extent of offering a reasonable explanation for the idol worship practised by the masses of India [41].

But the author does not in any way try to denigrate Indian religions or allāck the *Upanishads*, the *Gita* or any other sacral book of the Hindus [42]. A serious defect of this chapter is that it does not actually discuss Indian religions but provides information only on the different sects of Hinduism. He does not consider Buddhism as a separate religion nor does he write any thing about Jainism.

The Aristotle-Alexander legend so popular among the medieval Arab writers is recorded here. The statement regarding the influence of Greek philosophy on Indian philosophy through Pythagoras is incorrect [43]. No Indian philosopher is mentioned by name. The two sects of Indian philosophers discussed are vague and the problem of their identification can be solved only tentatively. They might be *SRAMANA* (celibates) and *GRHASTH* (married men with family).

There js no doubt that there are many incorrect statements about Indian religions in this chapter but it would be futile to expect scientific accuracy from an author of the twelfth century. Therefore, it would not be desirable to criticize the author for failing to provide correct and authentic information in view of the vast material which is available on the subject in the twentieth century. It has to be judged from the point of view of the information found in Arabic sources in the middle of the twelfth century but, even all of those may not have been available to al-Shahrastani.

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[39] See pp. 40-41 and 99-100 of the book.
[40] See sub-section: *'Abdat al-Aṣnām* tr. p. 52.
[41] See *Kitāb al-Hind* of al-Bīrūnī, pp. 84-86.
[42] For a modern author's attack on these sacred books see Arun Shourie, *Hinduism: Essence and Consequences: A study of the Upanishads, the Brahma Sutras and the Gita* (New Delhi: Vikas, 1979).
[43] See note 26 above.

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